

Papal Supremacy Denial

doc-papal-supremacy-denial

Leadership & Polity · Ordination · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.713
confidence medium

Statement under examination

No human bishop or council possesses supreme authority over the universal Church; no human teacher pronounces with the infallibility that belongs to Scripture alone as the rule of faith and life.

In plain language

The words here weigh whether the texts give one human leader a supreme, error free authority over the whole church that they reserve for God and his written word. The pivotal verse is Matthew 16:18, you are Peter and on this rock I will build my church. In the Greek the name addressed to the apostle is masculine, Petros, which the lexicon calls a detached stone, while the rock that is built on is feminine, petra, which the lexicon calls a mass of solid bedrock, and the words this and the that go with the feminine rock, not with Peter's name. So the two forms differ in both gender and sense. Even so, the rock can still be read as Peter himself, because a rock metaphor naturally takes the feminine word and Peter's Aramaic name carried no gender, which is why this stays genuinely open. The keys and the power to bind and loose are given to Peter alone in Matthew 16:19, where you bind is singular, yet the very same power is given to all the disciples together in Matthew 18:18, where you bind is plural, and the same keys word names the key of knowledge in Luke 11:52. In John 21 Jesus tells Peter to feed and shepherd the sheep, which is pastoral care language, not the language of ruling over others. Elsewhere Peter is openly corrected by Paul, is questioned by the Jerusalem believers, is one of three pillars alongside James and John, and calls himself a fellow elder. The foundation of the church is named as the apostles together in Ephesians 2:20 and as the twelve in Revelation 21:14, with Christ the one foundation in 1 Corinthians 3:11. All of this leans against a single supreme office. The reason this is recorded as contested rather than settled is that Peter is named first in the apostle list in Matthew 10:2, the rock saying can be read of Peter, and crucially no word anywhere names Rome, a successor, or a power passed on, so the very thing the proposition denies is left undefined by the words themselves.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0436	ἀντίστημι	anthistēmi	to oppose	14
G1006	βόσκω	boskō	to feed	9
G1124	γραφῇ	graphē	a writing	51
G1210	δέω	deō	to bind	154
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	114
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	15
G2786	Κηφᾶς	Kēphas	Cephas	9
G2807	κλεῖς	kleis	key	6

G3089	λύω	lyō	to loose	42
G3618	οικοδομέω	oikodomeō	to build	40
G4073	πέτρα	petra	rock	15
G4074	Πέτρος	Petros	Peter	156
G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimainō	to shepherd	11
G4413	πρώτος	prōtos	first	153

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The word-level data leans toward the denial of a transferable supreme Petrine office but cannot close the question. In Matt 16:18 the form addressed to the apostle is masculine Πέτρος (G4074), which the lexicon glosses as a detached stone, while the foundation is feminine πέτρα (G4073), glossed as a mass of live rock as distinct from πέτρος, and the demonstrative ταύτη and article τῇ are feminine, agreeing with πέτρα. The same keys and binding and loosing given to Peter in the singular (δήσης, λύσης, 2nd person singular, Matt 16:19) are given to the disciples in the plural (δήσητε, λύσητε, 2nd person plural, Matt 18:18), and John 21:15-17 gives Peter a pastoral βόσκει and ποιμαίνει charge, not a jurisdictional grant. Peter is opposed by Paul (ἀντίστην, Gal 2:11), questioned at Jerusalem (διεκρίνοντο, Acts 11:2), and is one of three στυλοὶ (Gal 2:9) and a συμπρεσβύτερος (1 Pet 5:1), while the foundation is the apostles plural (Eph 2:20, Rev 21:14) on Christ the only foundation (1 Cor 3:11). It stays disputed because πέτρα can defensibly be construed as Peter personally, Peter is named πρῶτος in the list (Matt 10:2), and the vocabulary simply does not name Rome, a successor, or an error-free office, so the SCOPE the proposition denies is underdetermined by the words.

Scripture

Matt.16.18 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος, G4073 πέτρα, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. σὺ εἶ Πέτρος, καὶ ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ οἰκοδομήσω μου τὴν ἐκκλησίαν, you are Peter and on this rock I will build my church. The morphology shows Πέτρος as nominative singular masculine and πέτρα as dative singular feminine, with the demonstrative ταύτη and article τῇ also feminine and agreeing with πέτρα, not with Πέτρος. The lexicon glosses Πέτρος as a detached stone and πέτρα as a mass of live rock as distinct from πέτρος, so the two forms differ in gender and in attested sense. The text addresses the apostle by name and builds on the rock, but the Greek does not by itself fix whether the rock is Peter, his confession, or Christ, and it says nothing of a successor or of Rome.

Matt.16.19 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2807 κλείς, G1210 δέω, G3089 λύω

Force. δώσω σοι τὰς κλεῖδας τῆς βασιλείας τῶν οὐρανῶν, καὶ ὃ ἐὰν δήσης, I will give to you the keys of the kingdom, and whatever you bind. The pronoun σοι and the verbs δήσης and λύσης are second person singular, addressed to Peter alone here. The same keys word κλείς is used elsewhere of the key of knowledge, Luke 11:52, so the keys image is not a technical term for a transferable office. The grant is real and singular in this verse, which a primacy reading can lean on.

Matt.18.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1210 δέω, G3089 λύω

Force. ὅσα ἐὰν δῆσητε ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς ἔσται δεδεμένα ἐν οὐρανῷ, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven. Here ὑμῖν and the verbs δῆσητε and λύσητε are second person plural, addressed to the disciples as a body, and the bound and loosed participles δεδεμένα and λελυμένα are neuter plural against the singular δεδεμένον and λελυμένον of Matt 16:19. The identical binding and loosing authority is therefore extended to the disciples plural, which weakens the idea that the Matt 16:19 grant marks out a unique office reserved to Peter and his successors.

John.21.16 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G1006 βόσκω

Force. Ποίμαινε τὰ πρόβατά μου, shepherd my sheep, with Βόσκε τὰ ἀρνία μου and Βόσκε τὰ πρόβατά μου in verses 15 and 17. The imperatives βόσκε and ποιμαίνε are second person singular present, a pastoral charge to feed and shepherd. The vocabulary is the language of caring for a flock, the same ποιμαίνω used of elders generally in Acts 20:28 and 1 Pet 5:2, not the language of jurisdiction or supreme rule. The text commissions Peter to pastor, but does not lexically grant a governing primacy over the whole church or over other apostles.

Matt.10.2 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4413 πρῶτος

Force. πρῶτος Σίμων ὁ λεγόμενος Πέτρος, first Simon who is called Peter. The adjective πρῶτος is nominative singular masculine and heads the list of the twelve apostles, naming Peter first. This is genuine textual prominence for Peter and is the lexical footing for a primacy reading. The word πρῶτος denotes first in sequence or rank in a listing, but it is applied here within a list of equals called apostles, and the same word ranks many ordinary things elsewhere, so it establishes leadership and prominence without by itself establishing a supreme jurisdictional office.

Gal.2.9 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2786 Κηφᾶς

Force. Ἰάκωβος καὶ Κηφᾶς καὶ Ἰωάννης, οἱ δοκοῦντες στῦλοι εἶναι, James and Cephas and John, who were reputed to be pillars. The noun στῦλοι is plural and names three men, with James listed first, so Cephas is one of several pillars rather than a single supreme head. The collegial plural here sits against a doctrine of one unaccountable supreme bishop.

Gal.2.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2786 Κηφᾶς, G0436 ἀντίστημι

Force. κατὰ πρόσωπον αὐτῷ ἀντέστην, ὅτι κατεγνωσμένος ἦν, I withstood him to his face because he stood condemned. Paul applies the aorist ἀντέστην to Cephas and the perfect passive participle κατεγνωσμένος, naming Peter as already under condemnation. A peer apostle publicly opposes Peter, which cuts against Peter holding an office that no one may correct.

Acts.11.2 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος

Force. διεκρίνοντο πρὸς αὐτὸν οἱ ἐκ περιτομῆς, those of the circumcision took issue with him. The imperfect διεκρίνοντο has the Jerusalem believers contending with Peter when he returns, and Peter then lays out his account in order, ἐξετίθετο καθεξῆς in verse 4, before the matter is settled. Peter is held to account by the assembly, which fits a peer answerable to the body rather than a supreme head above question.

Eph.2.20 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Force. ἐποικοδομηθέντες ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ προφητῶν, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus as the cornerstone, ἀκρογωνιαίου. The genitive τῶν ἀποστόλων is plural, so the church is founded on the apostles as a group, not on one apostle, and the cornerstone is Christ. This locates the foundation in a plurality, not in a single Petrine office.

Rev.21.14 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Force. θεμελίους δώδεκα, καὶ ἐπ' αὐτῶν δώδεκα ὀνόματα τῶν δώδεκα ἀποστόλων, twelve foundations, and on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles. The noun θεμελίους is plural and is numbered twelve, distributing the foundation across all twelve apostles equally. No single name is elevated above the others on the wall of the city.

1Cor.3.11 · **for** · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Force. θεμέλιον γὰρ ἄλλον οὐδεὶς δύναται θεῖναι παρὰ τὸν κείμενον, ὅς ἐστιν Ἰησοῦς Χριστός, no one can lay another foundation than the one laid, which is Jesus Christ. The singular θεμέλιον with οὐδεὶς and ἄλλον excludes any rival foundation and identifies it as Christ. Read with Eph 2:20 and Rev 21:14, the foundation language centers on Christ and the apostles plural, not on a single transferable Petrine seat.

1Pet.5.1 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος

Force. Πρεσβυτέρους οὖν ἐν ὑμῖν παρακαλῶ ὁ συμπρεσβύτερος, I exhort the elders among you as a fellow elder. Peter styles himself ὁ συμπρεσβύτερος, where the συν prefix places him alongside the elders he exhorts rather than above them. This self-description in collegial parity weighs against a claim that Peter held a unique supreme rank over the universal church.

Acts.17.11 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1124 γραφή

Force. ἀνακρίνοντες τὰς γραφὰς εἰ ἔχοι ταῦτα οὕτως, examining the Scriptures daily whether these things were so. The Bereans are called more noble for testing even apostolic preaching against the γραφάς, placing final verification in the written word rather than in the standing of the speaker, which bears on the second clause of the proposition about the rule of faith.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gal.2.14	Gal.2.11	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Ps.1.2	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	Ps.19.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.16.18 · addressed

σὺ εἶ Πέτρος, καὶ ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ οἰκοδομήσω μου τὴν ἐκκλησίαν. The morphology gives masculine Πέτρος (G4074, nominative singular masculine, glossed a detached stone) and feminine πέτρα (G4073, dative singular feminine, glossed a mass of live rock as distinct from πέτρος), with the feminine demonstrative ταύτῃ and feminine article τῇ agreeing with πέτρα. The gender and sense distinction is real, yet a defensible construal still reads πέτρα as Peter himself, since the underlying Aramaic name would not mark gender and a feminine noun is the natural form for the metaphor of the rock. This is genuinely open at the word level. It is addressed by noting that even on the personal reading the verse grants no transferable office and names no successor or Rome, but because the construal is not forced one way, the proposition cannot be lexically closed and is recorded as disputed.

Matt.16.19 · addressed

δώσω σοι τὰς κλεῖδας ... ὃ ἐὰν δήσῃς. The keys and the binding and loosing are given to Peter in the second person singular, which a primacy reading takes as a personal commission. This is addressed by the parallel in Matt 18:18, where the same δέω and λύω are second person plural to the disciples as a body, and by Luke 11:52 where the same κλεῖς word names the key of knowledge, showing the image is not a technical term for a unique transferable seat. The singular grant is real but the canon supplies a matching plural grant the words do not rank above it.

Matt.10.2 · addressed

πρῶτος Σίμων. Peter is named first in the apostle list, and parallel narratives show him leading and speaking first in Acts 1 to 5. This prominence is genuine and is the strongest lexical footing for a primacy reading. It is addressed by observing that πρῶτος here orders a list of men all called apostles, and that prominence, leadership, and being named first are not the same as a supreme jurisdictional office that the vocabulary nowhere defines, transfers, or attaches to a see. The word establishes that Peter is foremost, not that a supreme office exists or passes on.

Concordance traversed

G4074, G4073, G2786, G1210, G3089, G2807, G4413, G2310, G4165, G1006, G0436, G1577, G3618, G1124

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No CBGM apparatus covers the anchor verses. The only ingested ECM variant units are for 3 John, outside this question's scope, so not_in_ecm_scope holds. The Matt 16, Matt 18, John 21, and Gal 2 readings carry SBLGNT editorial sigla, for example the Κηφᾶς and Πέτρος spelling in Gal 2 and minor ἐάν placement, but none of these touch the masculine Πέτρος versus feminine πέτρα distinction, the singular versus plural binding and loosing, or the pastoral βόσκει and ποιμαίνει charge, so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. petrine_primacy, apostolic_collegiality

analogia scripturae invoked

petrine_primacy: complicates · On its strongest lexical form this lens reads πέτρα in Matt 16:18 as Peter himself, since the metaphor of a rock naturally takes the feminine noun and the underlying Aramaic name marks no gender, so the wordplay σὺ εἶ Πέτρος, ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ identifies the man as the rock on which the church is built. It adds that the keys and binding and loosing are given to Peter in the singular in Matt 16:19, that John 21:15-17 singles Peter out for the βόσκει and ποιμαίνει charge, and that Peter is named πρῶτος in Matt 10:2 and leads throughout Acts 1 to 5. On this reading the texts assign Peter a real personal primacy among the apostles, and the words leave room to extend that prominence into an enduring office.

apostolic_collegiality: supports · On its strongest lexical form this lens notes that Πέτρος is masculine and lexically a detached stone while the foundation πέτρα is feminine and lexically a mass of live rock, that the identical binding and loosing of Matt 16:19 is given to the disciples plural in Matt 18:18, and that the foundation is the apostles plural

in Eph 2:20 and the twelve in Rev 21:14 on Christ the only foundation in 1 Cor 3:11. It adds that Peter is opposed by Paul in Gal 2:11, questioned at Jerusalem in Acts 11:2, listed as one of three pillars in Gal 2:9, and calls himself a fellow elder, συμπρεσβύτερος, in 1 Pet 5:1. On this reading the apostles function as an accountable college and no word grants a single bishop a supreme transferable office or names a successor or Rome.

Both lenses are grammatically available on the anchor texts, which is why the verdict is disputed rather than a clean affirmation. The collegial reading has the wider canon spread and the gender and sense distinction of Πέτρος versus πέτρα plus the plural binding and loosing of Matt 18:18 on its side; the primacy reading has Peter's named prominence, the singular grant of Matt 16:19, and the open construal of πέτρα on its side. The decisive point for the SUPREMACY claim specifically is that no vocabulary in either reading supplies succession, transfer of office, Rome, or an error-free human pronouncement, so the scope the proposition denies is underdetermined by the words.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What teaching and governing authority, if any, do the texts assign to a single human leader or council over the whole church, whether such authority is unique to one figure or transferable to successors, and on what basis the rule of faith is identified.

The stem bundles two claims and frames both as denials: that no human bishop or council has supreme authority over the universal church, and that infallibility belongs to Scripture alone as the rule of faith. The second clause presupposes a sola-scriptura conclusion, and the first presupposes the denial of any supreme human office, so the proposition encodes its own answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form was used to test whether the lexical data independently warrants the denial of papal supremacy before scoring. pan_canonical was set to false in this pass because every anchor verse sits in the NT canon section; the lemmas spread widely across Gospels, Acts, the Pauline and general epistles, and the Apocalypse, but they do not span OT and NT or the law, prophets, and writings, so an honest reading is NT-internal breadth rather than pan-canonical spread.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.16.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.16.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.18.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.21.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4074
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4073
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0436
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.2.14

License audit

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MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent